Snow White & the Seven Microaggressions

By Laura Lane and Ellen Haun

NARRATOR: **(Pg 22 – 31)** Once upon a time . . . there lived a vain, evil, and verbally abusive queen, who was the stepmother to a teenager named Snow White. Stepmothers tend to get a bad rap in fairy tales, but this one was truly evil. The Queen was concerned Snow White would one day grow to be more beautiful than herself. Not to psychoanalyze the Evil Queen, but there were clearly some deep-seated issues happening for her to feel so insecure. Every morning the Evil Queen would look into her Magic Mirror and say:

EVIL QUEEN: Mirror, Mirror, on the wall, who is the fairest of them all?

MAGIC MIRROR: Beauty is a subjective social construct, the use of the word 'fair' is problematic because it means both 'white' and 'beautiful,' and I terribly hate casting judgment on appearances. But all that aside, you, my Queen, are the fairest of them all.

INTRODUCTION

*Snow White is a classic fairy tale. But in this **modernized** twist, the Evil Queen isn't just obsessed with beauty -- she's also completely clueless about how damaging her choice of words can be. The Magic Mirror, part therapist and part DEI consultant, tries to teach her about pronouns and microaggressions, not to mention the inappropriateness of targeting her opponents. And with a touch of fairy-tale chaos, we begin to understand how language, power, and self-awareness collide.*

In the words of Desmond Tutu "Language is very powerful. [It]does not just describe reality. [It]creates the reality it describes."

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NARRATOR: While the Queen was busy talking to mirrors, Snow White was out living large after moving into a crazy-cute cottage with seven dude roommates who were rarely home. Initially there was a big problem when they left their dishes in the sink and assumed Snow White would deal with the mess. But Snow White put a quick kibosh on that sitch by making a chore chart . . . One day, per usual, the Queen asked:

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EVIL QUEEN: Mirror, Mirror, on the wall, who is the fairest of them all?

NARRATOR: But before answering, the Mirror decided to pay the Evil Queen a compliment.

MAGIC MIRROR: You know, I've been meaning to tell you that your use of the gender neutral pronoun 'them' in your question is quite excellent and inclusive. For an Evil Queen, it's very impressive.

EVIL QUEEN: Thank you. Snow White explained to me that they identify as nonbinary and prefer the pronouns 'they' and 'them.' They aren't a maiden, like I thought. So, I say 'them' to make sure you include Snow White when I ask who is fairest in the kingdom. Because I'll murder hims, hers, xems, zes, hirs, theys, thems. Really anyone who is hotter than me.

MAGIC MIRROR: You are doing an excellent job of respecting Snow White's—

EVIL QUEEN: *(snapping)* Answer my question!

MAGIC MIRROR: Like I always say before I answer this question, beauty is a subjective —

EVIL QUEEN: Blah blah blah, answer the question.

MAGIC MIRROR: According to industrialized western white beauty standards, it's no longer you, my Queen. Snow White is the fairest of them all.

EVIL QUEEN: *(shouting, she takes off her tiara and throws it)* Dammit! Now I have to kill her.

MAGIC MIRROR: Hold up. You mean you have to kill ***them***. You were doing so well.

EVIL QUEEN: I'm too upset to think about language right now! It's been a huge hassle for me to have to remember every time I'm around her. Them. Whatever!

MAGIC MIRROR: No. It's not whatever. It's really important to Snow White, which is why they had a long conversation with you about it.

EVIL QUEEN: It's grammatically incorrect anyway.

MAGIC MIRROR: Not anymore . . . Language evolves.

EVIL QUEEN: Okay, fine. I want to kill *them* because *they* are more fair than me. Is that better?

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MAGIC MIRROR: In terms of pronouns, yes. In terms of content, absolutely not. Baby steps.

EVIL QUEEN: Great, let's discuss ***their*** murder.

MAGIC MIRROR: Can we focus on one problematic thing at a time? We'll get to why murder is bad later. But since we're on the topic of respectful language, I've been meaning to address something. You see, you have a tendency to commit something called microaggressions on a daily basis. With a lot of people. It's a problem.

EVIL QUEEN: Micro-what?

MAGIC MIRROR: Microaggressions. They are subtle insults made to marginalized people or mirrors. They are typically delivered in everyday interactions by well intentioned people, so imagine how bad they are delivered by an Evil Queen.

EVIL QUEEN: I do not do that. Ask my henchman! Hey, Mark, come over here! Tell the Mirror how nice I am.

NARRATOR: The henchman, who lost a leg in a sword fight years ago, came over in his wheelchair.

EVIL QUEEN: *(laughing)* You better slow down or you're going to get a speeding ticket in that thing!

MAGIC MIRROR: That, right there, was a microaggression. It's ableism.

EVIL QUEEN: Oh, come on! That's how we joke together. He likes it.

MARK: *(nervously)* Um, actually, your Royal Highness, ma'am, Evil Queen. I don't think it's funny. It makes me feel defined by my disability. I've just been too scared of you to say anything. You throw things.

EVIL QUEEN: You're just being lazy. You could totally walk and use that peg leg if you wanted to. Also, your shirt is ugly.

NARRATOR: There was a long silence in the room. The Magic Mirror blinked at the Evil Queen.

EVIL QUEEN: Okay, fine. I was being mean. But that time it was on purpose. Mark, you are dismissed. *(calling after him as he exits)* And bring me Bob, my second henchman.

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Let's get his opinion on whether I'm doing microaggressions or not. And in the future, you have no reason to be scared of me!

NARRATOR: Mark did as he was told. A few moments later, the Queen's second henchman, Bob, walked in.

EVIL QUEEN: Hi, Bob. Two things. First, I want you to behead Mark. Second, this Mirror thinks I'm committing microaggressions, so I need you to tell it how nice I am.

BOB: Yes, Evil Queen. You are so nice.

EVIL QUEEN: See, Mirror, I am so nice. Also, can we take a moment to compliment Bob on how great his English is. Where are you from again, Bob?

BOB: I'm from this kingdom, ma'am.

EVIL QUEEN: No, like, where are you from-from? Originally.

MAGIC MIRROR: *(interrupting)* Okay! That's enough. Those were a ***bunch*** of microaggressions, back to back! It might seem trivial to you, but when you told Bob his English was good, you implied that he is an outsider in this kingdom, which is a hidden insult. This creates a hostile work environment for Bob. Even more hostile than working for an Evil Queen.

EVIL QUEEN: It was a compliment! Bob ***doesn't*** look like he's from here.

MAGIC MIRROR: *(shouting)* Microaggression alert!

BOB: *(sheepishly, looking at the ground)* That hurts my feelings.

EVIL QUEEN: But, Bob, you can admit you're highly sensitive, right? I doubt the other foreign-looking henchman would feel the way you do.

BOB: I don't want to speak for all nonwhite henchmen. I can't possibly represent all of their perspectives. I wouldn't ask you to speak for all Evil Queens.

EVIL QUEEN: Obviously not. I'm special. I'm not like the other ones. . . Okay, I see your point there.

MAGIC MIRROR: We're making strides. I think you're learning that microaggressions can be unintentional, yet harmful. They are based on institutional oppression and often committed by those in power. And you are very powerful, my Evil Queen.

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EVIL QUEEN: Indeed I am! We're done here, Bob. Go behead Mark and then meet me by the guillotine. Don't worry, it's not for you. Well, maybe it is. It will be a surprise! Just meet me there. *(Bob nervously exits)*

Great. Now I have to kill both of my henchmen. Magic Mirror, who am I going to get to kill Snow White and those stupid seven dwarfs? Or, wait, let me guess, 'dwarf' isn't acceptable now?

MAGIC MIRROR: Actually, sometimes it is. The best thing to do is to ask the person what they'd like to be called. Some people with dwarfism prefer 'dwarf' and others prefer 'little people.' They're just people, who don't need to be defined by their size. In general, use their names and if you have to refer to their small stature, saying a 'person with dwarfism' is typically best.

EVIL QUEEN: So, I should say, 'Mirror, Mirror, on the wall, how should I kill Snow White and the seven men with dwarfism?'

MAGIC MIRROR: Exactly! In terms of language, at least, you're getting it. At the end of the day, they're just seven adult men who live in a house together. And let's be honest, that's the weird part.

EVIL QUEEN: You know what all this reminds me of? That time I was at the Convention for Evil Leaders and I was the only Evil Queen at the table. The Evil Kings wouldn't listen to me! I had this great idea about how to steal a cyclops and one of the kings pretended it was his idea. So annoying.

MAGIC MIRROR: Yes! Microaggressions are often committed against women, good and evil.

EVIL QUEEN: I ended up having the cyclops behead all of the Evil Kings.

MAGIC MIRROR: Of course you did, Your Highness. In the future, let's try to be a little less defensive when someone tells you that you've offended them, be constantly vigilant against your own unconscious biases, and remember that murderous henchmen have feelings, too.

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EVIL QUEEN: This has given me a lot to think about. However, don't forget that since Snow White is still the hottest ***person*** in the kingdom, we still have to kill ***them***, as well as the seven men ***with dwarfism***, and my hench***people*** Mark and Bob, whom I will not define by their disability or racial background. *(smiles proudly)*

MAGIC MIRROR: *(beaming back at her)* We've done great work here today. Tomorrow, we'll tackle murder.

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